

Q How do I do Kegel exercises? Is there a way to be sure I'm doing them correctly?

Pelvic-floor exercises or Kegels—named after US gynecologist Arnold Kegel—are the exercises that keep the pelvic-floor muscles toned so that they are strong enough to assist the second stage of labor (see opposite).

It's important to perform Kegel exercises daily while you are pregnant, since the pelvic-floor muscles work with your deep transverse abdominal and back muscles to stabilize your spine, support your baby, and help prevent stress incontinence. However, don't overexercise your pelvic floor when you do this internal movement—more than 100 squeezes a day could make it difficult for the muscles to relax during the birth, which then makes it harder for the baby to make his way out.

First, find out what your pelvic-floor muscles feel like: imagine you are drawing up water into your vagina. Another way to find the muscles is to stop urinating toward the end of your flow (don't do this in the

middle since it could lead to a urinary-tract infection). The muscles you tighten to do either of these actions are your pelvic-floor muscles. The movement is completely internal and not visible to other people.

Benefits of Kegel exercises

Do them anytime, anywhere, in any position. Practice them while you make coffee, wait in a line, or to the rhythm of a song. If you only do a few at a time, the cumulative effects will be worth every one, and may even help to improve your sex life. If you suffer from stress incontinence, you should notice a difference after about six weeks.

DO A SIMPLE KEGEL EXERCISE

Here is a simple routine you can follow. Try to do the whole sequence three times a day. You might find it helps to lift starting with the rear muscles and then moving forward to the front, before holding and then releasing.

1 SQUEEZE THE MUSCLES

Sit comfortably in a chair with your feet flat on the floor and your back straight. Keep your body and your face relaxed. Pull up and squeeze your pelvic-floor muscles as tightly as they will go and hold for ten seconds. Release the muscles.

2 SLOW SQUEEZE AND RELEASE

Repeat the squeeze 9–20 times, holding each for ten seconds. Do not use your abdomen or buttock muscles. Make sure you rest the muscles for ten seconds between contractions.

3 QUICK SQUEEZE AND RELEASE

Finally, do a set of quick squeezes. Following the natural rhythm of your breath, lift the muscles as you inhale. Exhale and release and briefly relax the muscles. Repeat ten times.

If you find it hard to know whether you are locating the right muscles, it can help to try doing the exercises in different positions. Below are some options that will help you focus all your attention on the correct area and relax the rest of your body.



Exercise ball or firm bean bag Place the ball against a wall and sit up straight with your knees apart. Place your hands lightly on your lower abdomen. Relax your face and body.



Kneeling on floor head down Kneel down on the floor, then get down gently onto all fours, place your elbows on the floor, and rest your head on your hands. Focus on the sense of space around your pelvic floor.



Astride a chair Sit upright on a chair with your knees wide apart and your feet at an angle that allows for maximum stability. Rest your hands on the front of the chair seat. Relax your face and body and focus on your pelvic area.